Bald in the Land of Big Hair

By Joni Rogers

JONI: **(Pg 1)** When tomorrow was still a given and ignorance was still bliss, I was floating along like a paper sailboat on a lazy river, too caught up in my life to know that I was dying. But the day you're diagnosed with cancer, you stop dying and start surviving. You stop living and start staying alive.

INTRODUCTION

Being a parent while living with cancer is physically and emotionally exhausting. You do everything you can to protect your child from the pretend monsters under the bed and the real monsters lurking in the world. Yet, here at your doorstep is the most real and feared monster of them all, Cancer, and you have no choice but to let it in.

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JONI: **(Pg 42-47)** Dr. Ro made a concise explanation of the diagnosis: diffuse large-cell lymphoma, a high-grade, swiftly spreading cancer. *(To Dr. Ro)* So what does this mean? Does this mean . . . am I dying? *(to audience)* But Dr. Ro was reluctant to place a statistical probability on my survival, dodging the question with cautionary statements like . . .

DR. RO: This is a very serious situation. It is important that we move ahead quickly.

JONI: *(to audience)* Chemotherapy, she said, had proved successful in such cases, and she was ordering six to eight cycles, for starters. *(To Dr. Ro)* No, I don't want chemotherapy. I want to investigate my alternatives.

DR. RO: *(bluntly)* Your alternatives are chemotherapy or death. You have very good chance of getting remission with chemotherapy.

JONI: But I read in this book-it said chemotherapy is like removing a wart with a blowtorch.

DR. RO: That's not an appropriate comparison. A wart doesn't kill you.

JONI: *(to audience)* Her eyes never wavered from mine, and they held not a trace of

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apology, sympathy, or doubt. She laid out the gruesome possibilities in clinical nomenclature, couching blunt realities like "barfing" and "agony" in palatable terms like "nausea" and "discomfort." This was the first time I heard the word *alopecia.*

DR. RO: The loss of one's hair.

JONI: *(to audience)* The word that starts with *B* and rhymes with "appalled." *(To Dr. Ro)* It doesn't matter. That's the least of my worries.

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JONI: **(Pg 109)** When I was diagnosed with cancer, Malachi [my son] was a savvy second grader. He was old enough to know facts, but young enough to struggle with implications and smart enough that there was no keeping the truth from him. He accepted with a silent nod each time we explained a new side effect or defined a new clinical term, and I would hear him at night, whispering in the dark.

MALACHI: Are you going to die, Mom?

JONI: *(to Malachi)* I'm trying not to. I promise I'll do everything possible to stay here with you as long as I can. *(to audience)* Later, when I wasn't too sure, I started adding something about how he was a part of me and I was part of him because he grew right out of my own body, so no matter what, I would always be with him.

(Pg 112-113) A child's life is made up of fragile combinations. The irresistible upward motion of precariously stacked building blocks. The intricate logic of a Tinker Toy Ferris wheel. The smooth symbiosis of peanut butter and jelly.

MALACHI: Mom . . .

JONI: I awoke to the feeling of a small hand patting on my cheek, but it took me a moment to open my eyes. *(to Malachi)* Sweetie, please. Mommy doesn't feel good. Just turn to the Disney channel, okay?

MALACHI: But I'm hungry.

JONI: Can you make yourself a PB and J?

MALACHI: No, you have to make it.

JONI: Sweetie, could you just give it a try? C'mon. Be my big boy.

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MALACHI: Why can't you get up and make it? It'll just take a minute. Then you can lay down again.

JONI: All right. *(to audience)* I sat up on the couch and dragged my feet to the floor. A wave of nausea and dizziness engulfed me, and I rested my head forward in my hands. *(to Malachi)* Malachi, I can't. I'm sorry, sweetie, you're going to have to do it yourself.

MALACHI: *(whining)* Nooooo *(pause, thinking)* I don't feel good. I'm sick. You have to, Mom! You have to do it.

JONI: You're not too sick, Malachi, you're just too lazy. Now would you please . . . oh . . . Lord . . . *(to audience)* I struggled up from the couch and lurched toward the bathroom.

MALACHI: *(groaning)* Are you going to throw up ***again****?*

JONI: I closed the door behind me. In a little while, I heard the sound of the refrigerator door. Then the silverware drawer. Then a chair scraping across the kitchen floor.

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JONI: **(Pg 119-123)** When I woke up the next day, Malachi wouldn't speak to me. I tried to jolly him through the first half of the morning, then let him avoid me until lunchtime. *(to Malachi)* Hey, Ike. Can I make you a PB and J?

MALACHI: I'm not hungry.

JONI: Oh, c'mon. I'll put more peanut butter on it. Way more. It'll be nice and messy.

MALACHI: Why don't you go lay down if you're so sick.

JONI: Well, thanks for your concern, Dr. Snidely, but I'm feeling better today. *(to audience)* Cringing at the cranky sound of that, I deliberately softened my tone and laid my hand on his head. *(to Malachi)* That was kind of rough yesterday, I know. But Dr. Ro said it's normal to be kind of rough the first few days after chemo, and then it gets better. *(Kneeling to be on eye level)* It gets better, right?

MALACHI: *(Softly then gaining strength as he is overcome with anger and sadness)* You're not sick! You're just lazy! You don't play -- you don't read books -- you just lay around on the couch all day! You don't want to go to the park or do art projects or science experiments like we always-"

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JONI: Malachi, I still want to do those things, but some days it's too hard for me. *(Pause)* Ike, life is full of stuff we have a tough time understanding . . .

MALACHI: *(Mimicking in a jeering falsetto)* *Life is full of stuff we have a tough time understanding.*

JONI: Hey! *(Grabbing his arm and jerking him close – she speaks harshly right in his face)* I'm sorry this is hard for you, and someday you can tell your analyst how horrible it was having me for a mother, but in the meantime, I will not allow you to speak to me this way, do you understand?

MALACHI: *(Pulling away)* I think you ***like*** having cancer! I wish ***I*** had cancer!

JONI: *(She slaps him hard, across the face)* Don't you ever, *ever* say that again! *(immediately appalled, she covers her face with her hands and cries)*

MALACHI: *(racing away to his room)* I wish you would just die! *(slamming the door to his room)* I hate you!

JONI: But I hated myself more. After five minutes, a glass of water, and a few deep breaths *(take calming breaths)*, I followed him down the hall. *(knocking gently on the door)* Ike? Hey, can I come in? *(no answer, after a moment she opens the door and steps inside)* All right. First, I'm sorry I hit you. That was wrong, wrong, *wrong,* and I'm sorry. *(silence)* Malachi, I know you don't wish you had cancer. And I know you don't hate me. And I know that you know none of those other things you said are true. You're just mad because I'm sick, and that's -- it's just . . .

MALACHI: *(eyes filled with tears and voice quivering)* Mom, I don't want you to -- I don't wish -

JONI: I know. But I wouldn't blame you if you did. Because a few times lately . . . I've wished it myself. I've wished I would just die, Ike. There are times it seems like that would be easier. *(to audience)* He closed his eyes and shook his head, fighting not to cry. He tried to turn his face toward his pillow, but I pulled him onto my lap. *(to Malachi)* Malachi, I don't blame you for being mad at me. Everything's out of whack right now, and it seems like it's all my fault. But I really think I'm going to start getting better soon. And if I do die, it won't be because you wished it. Just the opposite. Every day I go on like this -- well, it's hard, Ike. And I don't

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know if I would have had the courage to do it if it wasn't for you. You make me want to stay alive. You're so full of surprises. I just have to stay around and see how you turn out.

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JONI: **(Pg 127)** Trying to be an effective parent when physical and emotional reserves are depleted. The uncertainty and the painful truths that must be told. A child's grief and anger and fear. Though I couldn't see it at the time, Malachi's experience mirrored mine, emotion for emotion, challenge for challenge. He climbed his private mountain and came down changed, just as I did. Both of us discovered reservoirs of unexpected strength, but each of us left a little of our innocence behind.

(Pg 250-251) Someone sent me a little wooden plaque that said, "Adversity is a blessing." But I disagree. The overcoming of adversity is a blessing. Adversity is not a blessing. Adversity just sucks.

"Cancer is the definition of who I am now," said one survivor in a magazine article I read a while back. But if cancer is what we are, and all our efforts are bent toward killing cancer, then what's to become of us?

Cancer is not what I am. It's not a gift or a curse. It's not a blessing in disguise (unless that is one ***dang*** good disguise!). It's not the scourge of God, not the Red Badge of Courage, nor is it a purely clinical phenomenon. Personally, I like Malachi's definition: "Cancer is what happens when your cells decide to go funky." We are who we are, regardless of a few funky cells, and surviving cancer is the same as emerging from any of life's refining fires.

I'm still wondering if and when I'll ever "get over it." After all this time, cancer can still reach out and grab me with insidious tentacles of survivor's guilt, fears of reoccurrence, and self-pitying fantasies of what might have been had the beast passed me by.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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